



ART START-UP MAAZI MERCHANT IS ON A MISSION TO BRING INDIA'S FORGOTTEN ART BACK HOME

BY ARNAV DAS SHARMA

PHOTO BY HARDIK CHHABRA

I

In a studio filled with the hum of printers and the scent of archival paper, Parakram Kakkar (*pictured*) examines *Three Princesses from Mysore*, a portrait by Thomas Hickey, which marks a colonial turning point. After Tipu Sultan's defeat, the East India Company introduced the smallpox vaccine to secure its rule. Queen Lakshmi Ammani, widowed by the disease, ensured vaccination for princesses. By 1807, over a million Indians had been inoculated, with the portrait symbolising British use of art to shape India's image.

Such paintings, housed in museums abroad like London's National Portrait Gallery, remain largely inaccessible to Indians. Kakkar's Maazi Merchant, launched in early 2023, aims to change that. The company's stated aim is housed in the name itself: 'Maazi' is an Urdu word that means the past, or history. And it wants to make this 'past' accessible. How? By making high-quality prints of these Indian artworks—Mughal miniatures, East India Company paintings like *Three Princesses*, and engravings, among many others—and sell them here in India. And they are the first ones to do so.

For Kakkar, reclaiming India's art isn't just about reproducing images—it's about dismantling colonial gatekeeping. Many of the works Maazi Merchant revives were commissioned by European patrons: East India Company officers documenting the land they ruled, botanists chronicling native plants, or British travellers capturing courtly life. "These pieces were painted by Indian artists, but their stories were filtered through foreign patrons," Kakkar explains. "Today, by returning them to Indian homes, we are reclaiming not just the works but also the narrative."

But in making these artworks accessible to Indians here, haven't existing copyright laws been a hindrance? "Courts have repeatedly held that such works belong to the public," says Kakkar, a lawyer by training. And yet, major custodians of heritage art, including the British Museum and National Portrait Gallery, continue to assert restrictions over digitised works, often placing innovation at odds with gatekeeping.

At Maazi Merchant, Kakkar is determined to challenge this status quo. "Preserving art isn't about locking it behind licensing agreements," he says. "These works

111